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Pressing beyond the limits: Crisis theory between Simon Clarke and Robert Brenner

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Abstract

This article stages an encounter of crisis theories between Robert Brenner, an influential figure of Political Marxism, and Simon Clarke, an understudied figure of Open Marxism. Its central conceit is that what we call "Marxist crisis theory" is a collective endeavor to extend and refine Marx's own unfinished work on crisis and that, despite Clarke's fierce criticisms of Brenner's controversial long downturn framework, the two theorists share a number of overlooked and surprising affinities. By tracing their shared theoretical opponents, I show that Brenner and Clarke share an antipathy for the profit squeeze and falling rate of profit accounts of crisis. Most significantly, I show that Clarke's theoretical elaboration of capital's underlying tendency to overproduction sets capital's drive for self-expanding profitability against the concrete demands of realization and the "limits of the market," arguing that these core principles of Clarke's crisis theory are also the methodological pillars of Brenner's long downturn framework. Finally, I suggest that Brenner and Clarke's parallel contributions argue for the inextricability of capitalist crisis with the historical role of the capitalist state as a social form, where the historical development of the capitalist state apparatus is contingent upon the tumult of working-class self-organization and revolt yet ossifies into legal and monetary institutional forms opposed to the interests of the class conflicts that birthed them. Within these constraints, class struggle cannot help but press beyond the historical limits dictated by crisis and by the social form of the state.

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Introduction

A recent flurry of commentaries (Ackerman, 2023; Benanav, 2023; Rahtz, 2023; Roberts, 2023) has reminded us that a perennial question hanging over Robert Brenner's "long downturn" framework is to what extent his historical analysis of decades-long capitalist stagnation expresses an authentically Marxist theory of crisis. For all its empirical and historical richness, Brenner's work has apparently failed to respond to the theoretical accusation that it contains a variety of deviations from a perspective on crisis derived from Marx's published and unpublished writings. This question has been made all the more persistent by Brenner's own patent lack of interest in adjudicating it. As is often noted, Brenner's (1998, 2006) *The Economics of Global Turbulence* contains precious few explicit citations of Marx or to theories of crisis in the Marxist tradition. But it is much less frequently observed that one of these rare footnotes on Marx also offered a nod to Simon Clarke's 1980s and 1990s work on economic crisis, as Clarke (1999) himself could not fail to observe in his critical review of Brenner's text.

This article stages an encounter of crisis theories between the majorly influential Brenner, a key intellectual figure in the post-2008 Marx revival, and the greatly understudied Clarke, whose marginality to the Marx revival is belied by the sophistication of his work (O'Kane, 2023a). To the extent that Brenner and Clarke were each readers of the other from across the aisle of two very distinct schools of Marxism, their mutual citations occurred in passing textual references or in common opposition to theoretical opponents, above all on topics of crisis, the long-term dynamics of accumulation, and the relationship of capitalist state and class struggle. These overlapping thematic interests, alongside a shared nose for polemic and a desire to intervene in contemporary debates for the purposes of political clarification, were exemplified in presentations that Brenner and Clarke each gave at the 1988 International Conference on Regulation Theory in Barcelona, which formed the basis for their trenchant published critiques of the Regulationist approach to Marxist political economy (Brenner and Glick, 1991; Clarke, 1988a).

In the spirit of these resonances, I argue that Clarke's fierce but abbreviated critique of Brenner contains a number of overlooked and surprising affinities between Brenner's long downturn thesis and Clarke's investigations into Marxist crisis theory. While Brenner (2006) gestures at the goal of producing "an adequate theory of crisis" (p. 25), he rarely leans at length on Marx to do so. For his part, Clarke, who purports to "criticise Brenner's enterprise from the perspective of Marx's own analysis" (1999: p. 58), also concludes his excursus *Marx's Theory of Crisis* with the scandalous assertion that "Marx did not have a theory of crisis, in the sense that such a theory has comes to play a role within Marxism" (Clarke, 1993: 228). The methodological challenge of legitimating a Marxist crisis theory per se, which Clarke raises outright and which has long been at stake in the Marxist reception of Brenner, is the point of departure for the Clarkean reading of Brenner advanced in these pages. Even in *Keynesianism, Monetarism and the Crisis*

of the State, his most overtly historical work on crisis, Clarke characterizes his interventions as primarily theoretical rather than empirical. In this article, I argue that Clarke's account of crisis clarifies the *theoretical* specificity of Brenner's long downturn iconoclasm with respect to Marxist crisis theory. I therefore trace four touchstones of the Brenner–Clarke convergence: first, the simultaneous analysis of periodic crises alongside capital's secular dynamics; second, the heterodox refusal of a strong causal relation between class struggle and the rate of profit; third, a congruent grounding of crisis theory in the tendency to overproduction; and fourth, the reappearance of class struggle in crisis theory through an antifunctionalist, antistructuralist view of the capitalist state.

Crisis

The specific difference of a Marxist theory of crisis is the affirmation of the necessary rather than contingent or accidental nature of crises. To show that crises are merely possible is "a relatively trivial exercise" (Clarke, 1990: 442). The latent possibility of crisis is inherent, as Marx showed in the early chapters of *Capital, Vol. 1*, in the basic contradiction between use value and value and in the generalization of the exchange relation on the basis of the mediatory power of the money form. Crisis is implied by the very existence of the monetary system, which is why all episodic crises in capitalism's historical development take the superficial appearance of monetary crises and a violent proliferation of nonpayments, including the very many individual crises that make appearances in Brenner's work: the oil crisis, the debt crisis, the 1997 Asian financial crisis, and the 2008–2009 financial crisis. Crises occupy a peculiar position within Marxist thought because they are at once the most "superficial and transient expression" of capital's destructiveness (idle capital, gluts of commodities, hoards of money, and fire sales of assets), even as they express "the most fundamental contradiction" of social existence under the capitalist mode of production (Clarke, 1993: 229). Marxist crisis theory is, therefore, a complex endeavor that articulates the underlying principles and dynamics of capitalist accumulation while also accounting for observable trends and exceptions suggested by statistical indicators and the tangled knots of economic history. For this reason, as Paul Mattick (2018) has argued, the straightforward application of Marx's theories of capital's laws of motion to the empirics of actual crisis phenomena is an inevitably tormented exercise in the juggling of levels of abstraction.

Is Brenner's "long downturn" synonymous with "crisis"? The terminological slippages in Brenner's text led Clarke, for one, to conclude that Brenner's is not a theory of crisis at all but "really a theory of secular stagnation" (1999: p. 62 n. 5). But Brenner (2006), who readily distinguishes the short-term strife of crisis from the long-term debilitation of stagnation (p. 2; 14; 31), is chiefly concerned neither with outlining the abstract possibility of crisis nor with the mechanics underlying various individual crises but with a historical periodization in which a 1965–1973 "crisis of profitability," because it is never resolved, sustains a protracted world-scale downturn. Brenner's crisis theory maps the proximate ignition of crisis in the manufacturing sectors of the advanced capitalist economies from 1965 to 1973, which, by virtue of the extended failures of remedial action, occasions the long-term slowdown and stagnation of accumulation on a global, cross-sectoral scale. With formulas like "long-term systemic crisis of profitability" or "a slowly

ripening crisis on a system-wide scale" (Brenner, 2006: 152, 242, 338), Brenner's crisis theory aims not to render crisis and stagnation indistinct but instead to synthesize both a historical episode of crisis and the systemic failure to follow the crisis to its fully generalized, dramatic conclusion. Indeed, what protracted stagnating profitability in the advanced capitalist core signals is the conspicuous *absence* of the kinds of "system-shaking crisis" (Brenner, 2006: xxiii) that might restore profitability and dynamism.

The burden shouldered by Brenner's (2006) analysis, its "imposing task" (p. xix), is not one of explaining the proximate mechanical causes of a specific crisis but of accounting for the recurrent necessity of crises in light of the secular tendencies of capitalist development in 20th-century economic history. This experiment in periodization is a necessarily fraught attempt to thread the needle between an empiricist appeal to historical contingency and a reductionist refuge in capital's immutable laws of motion (Clarke, 1992: 133). Brenner's central challenge to the economic orthodoxy is that the capitalist system "by its very modi operandi" breeds not only crisis but also long booms and long downturns. Brenner, then, does not only offer a theory of periodic crises, recurrent business cycle slumps, or sudden financial shocks, nor only a theory of the broader secular tendencies of capital accumulation, as Aaron Benanav (2023) has suggested with his characterization of Brenner as essentially a "long-wave theorist." Rather, he attempts the much more challenging task of describing a coherent relation between the two. Marx himself, as Clarke (1993) pointed out and as Heinrich (2013a) has more recently argued, wrote extensively on both periodic crises and on the secular tendencies of capitalist development but never provided a coherent account of their interrelation. What we call "Marxist crisis theory" is nothing other than the collective and still-incomplete endeavor to extend and refine Marx's own unfinished work on crisis.

The rate of profit and class struggle

Brenner is an idiosyncratic contributor to the crisis theory tradition because he insists upon the importance of the rate of profit as an indicator of economic compulsion and regulator of the dynamism of accumulation, even as he rejects many prevalent explanations for the decline in profitability. His long downturn framework defends the merits of marshaling the rate of profit as a periodizing tool in analyzing capitalist development (Duménil and Lévy, 1993), even as it repudiates two major accounts of falling profitability that gained currency in Marxist circles in the 1970s: the profit squeeze thesis and the law of the tendency of the rate of profit to fall (henceforth "LTRPF"). Brenner collectively terms these the "supply-side explanations" of the 1960s–1970s profitability crisis.

Clarke points out that neither the profit squeeze nor the LTRPF was a significant feature of Marxist crisis theory until the 1970s advent of falling profit rates as an undeniable material fact, to which these theories were a then-novel response, and a definitive historical turn in the intellectual evolution of Marxist crisis theory. In fact, the profit squeeze thesis, as associated with Glyn and Sutcliffe (1972), and the LTRPF theory, as advocated by David Yaffe (1972) and Mario Cogoy (1973) and further systematized by Fine and Harris (1979), were both advanced as rival explanations for the 1970s crisis years in the pages of the *Bulletin of the Conference on Socialist Economics*, the predecessor journal to *Capital & Class* (Clarke, 1980). As a core contributor to the Conference on

Socialist Economics (CSE), Clarke's keen familiarity with these debates allowed him to put forth stern critiques of both sides. In this section, I view Brenner's engagement with the CSE crisis theory debates not as some antiquarian "exercise in nostalgia" (Fine et al., 1999: 49) but as a starting point for considering Brenner and Clarke as kindred crisis theorists by way of their common targets of critique.

The profit squeeze thesis locates the fall in profit rates in the success of working-class militancy, which, in the distributional struggle over wage levels, tilted the balance of forces in labor's favor. Higher wages lead to depressed profits, and labor's feast is capital's famine. In Clarke's (1993: 57) initial diagnosis, the notion that falling profits were some hydraulic expression of class struggle directed the blame for capitalism's crisis-ridden tendencies toward the working class, rather than toward the internal contradictions of capital accumulation itself. This conjured up ideologically disastrous implications, including that a moderation or elimination of militant class struggle was the precondition for the economic dynamism of the system. Later, Clarke (1999: 57) would note approvingly that it was Brenner who "finally, and incontrovertibly, destroys the 'profit squeeze' explanation." Brenner did so by showing empirically that labor militancy in the advanced industrial economies produced neither a rising tide of real wages through the extraction of monetary concessions from the capitalist class nor a fall in productivity through resistant slacking and idling on the shop floor and that these trends held fast across both the apex of the postwar boom between 1958 and 1965 and the early tilt toward the long downturn between 1966 and 1973 (Brenner, 2006: 101–108). But Brenner's (2006) equally devastating theoretical objection (p. 21–25) was the relatively simple observation that the profit squeeze thesis must be universalizable in time and space in order to hold true and that its failure to meet this criterion is obvious. Struggles over the wage, precisely because they involve "historical and moral elements" (Marx, 1976: 275) determined politically by the contingencies of localized class antagonism, cannot generate systemwide downturns. The global stagnation of profitability that Brenner records was neither isolated to national economies with the most acute concentrations of organized labor militancy nor reversed by capital's widely successful assault on labor from the 1980s on.

While the profit squeeze thesis has largely receded into obscurity in the wake of the withering criticism of Brenner and the even more decisive criticism of historical experience, the LTRPF has lost none of its controversial currency since its 1970s revival as a cornerstone to a certain flavor of Marxist orthodoxy (Kliman, 2012; Mattick, 2015; Moseley, 1991; Roberts, 2016; Shaikh, 1978). Most elementarily, it is an algebraic postulate that the rate of profit must fall if the organic composition of capital rises in a greater proportion than that of the rate of surplus value or the rate of exploitation. This is a big if, since the very technological improvements and developments of the productive forces that drive increases in the organic composition of capital also simultaneously foster the greater productivity of labor and a resultant increase in the rate of exploitation. In no axiomatic sense, then, must the rise of the organic composition of capital necessarily, or in all cases, outpace that of the rate of surplus value to produce an inevitable, lawlike movement of the profit rate downwards. Marxist debates on the LTRPF, especially as recently ignited by Heinrich (2013a, 2013b), differ widely in their evaluation of a falling profit rate as a logical *tendency* of capitalist accumulation,

from Heinrich's assertion that the LTRPF was only a marginal piece of Marx's crisis theory, an indeterminate formula from the manuscript of *Capital Vol. 3* for which Marx could never muster definitive proof, to the objection led by Kliman et al. (2013) that the LTRPF remains an indispensable logical explanation behind the observable fall in capitalist profits in the 20th and 21st centuries.

The stakes of the often bitter Marxist debates over the LTRPF lie in the implications of the declining dynamism of capitalist accumulation for the fate of value as a social form of wealth (Bonefeld, 2014; Moraitis, 2022). Going back to the early 20th-century work of Henryk Grossman (2021), the LTRPF can evoke images of an imminent breakdown of capitalism or an apocalyptic general crisis of such unprecedented severity that opens a window for revolutionary action by the global working class. But in the far bleaker diagnosis of the *Wertkritik* school (Bolt Rasmussen and Routhier, 2019; Kurz, 2014), the terminal decline of capitalist profitability is immanent to the value-form itself and conversely displaces, rather than affirms, the working class as an agent of revolutionary change. Marx's ambiguous syntagm of a "law of a tendency" has accordingly produced opposing scholarship in Marxist crisis theory. The most influential partisans of the LTRPF understand this tendency as a diagnosis of a long-term trend fall in profit rates, to be confirmed in the empirical data (Kliman, 2012; Moseley, 1991; Roberts, 2016). But the opposing view, crystallized in Geert Reuten's (2004) innovative riposte, leans upon even more granular readings of Marx's economic manuscripts of 1861–1865 to suggest that, far from being convinced of the rate of profit's ultimate long-run trend fall, Marx understood it to be subject to nondetermining, cyclical variations that offer no easy diagnosis of the capitalist system's "historical destination" (p. 185).

In the face of the weighty inheritance of this exegetical tradition, the notable shared idiosyncrasy between Brenner and Clarke is a desire to shift the focus of Marxist crisis theory away from the LTRPF debates. Brenner has little truck with the LTRPF as a secular tendency and confines himself to a few sparing dismissals, whereas Clarke's critiques are frontal. Clarke stresses that the LTRPF is far from the only secular tendency of accumulation examined in Marx's economic manuscripts and indeed that it is not even the only secular tendency of accumulation resulting from a rising organic composition of capital. At least as crucial is the "absolute general law of capitalist accumulation" that Marx (1976) deploys as the narrative crescendo of *Capital, Vol. 1*, in which an increasing organic composition of capital tends to expel labor from the workplace and create ever-larger relative surplus populations of wageless proletarians (Clarke, 2001: 68; Davis, 2005; Endnotes, 2009; Marx, 1976). More pertinently, the LTRPF cannot stand as a basic foundation for crisis theory even if one accepts that it holds as a secular tendency and even if one believes that it occupies a privileged place in Marx's thought. Crises cannot be deduced from a falling rate of profit, since the minimal requirement for continued cycles of investment and accumulation is that the profit rate, however low or falling, remains above zero. Moreover, since a falling rate of profit is eminently compatible with a swelling *mass* of profit, the field of investment can still remain fertile through processes of the concentration and centralization of capital, through which individual capitals may reduce costs and expand outputs. "Every crisis," Clarke (1993) writes, "is marked by a fall in the rate of profit" (p. 56), but this is not a claim of causality. To state that a falling profit rate is the necessary

expression of periodic crises is a very different proposition from the unprovable claim that periodic crises are made necessary by falling profit rates. In order to make the causal leap from a tendentially falling profit rate to crisis, defenders of the LTRPF must have recourse to more proximate and contingent mismatches between investment and consumption (Weeks, 1981), thereby confessing that the abstractness of the law has little to say about the disproportionalities that instantiate an actual crisis (Clarke, 1990: 446).

For Clarke, the adherents of the profit squeeze (the "neo-Ricardians") and of the LTRPF (the "fundamentalists") were each expressing, through the long CSE debates, two facets of a common fallacy. While the profit squeeze thesis implies a mechanical translation of the outcomes of wage-based struggles into implications for the profit rate, the LTRPF framework generalizes this idea by identifying the direct process of production as a privileged site of analysis for crisis theory. This implies the major theme of a strong causal relationship between class struggle and the rate of profit, with minor variations in the directions of causality. For the Regulationists (Aglietta, 2015), class struggle provokes a fall in the rate of profit through both a wage-based profit squeeze and a more complex, "post-Fordist" restructuring of production in the form of the increasing technical composition of capital and newly deskilled labor processes (Brenner and Glick, 1991; Davis, 1978). In more recent debates surrounding the latest waves of labor upsurge (Holdren, 2022; Smith, 2021), this logic can also play out in reverse so that the falling rate of profit itself may appear as the outer political limit of struggles over the wage and antagonisms at the point of production.

Such productionist approaches to the 1970s crisis are untenable for both Brenner and Clarke, for illuminatingly distinct reasons. Brenner's concern is one of historically situated explanatory validity, where the burden of a periodization scheme must be to account for "the *simultaneous and general* character of the crisis on an international scale, the *suddenness* of its onset, and the extreme *sharpness* and *depth* of the fall" (Brenner and Glick, 1991: 102). If the site of surplus value production was indeed the ultimately determining instance, then the proliferation of empirical differences across national or sectoral boundaries *between* production processes—variegated institutional structures mediating the intensity of class struggle, differential trajectories in productivity growth and the rate of exploitation, and the uneven rate and extent of technological change—should have had a similar indeterminate effect on the international rate of profit. Neither in the 1970s nor at any point in the history of capitalist development were shopfloor struggles decisive in dictating the breadth and pace of technical change or in reversing revolutions in the productivity of labor outputs on an epochal scale (Brenner and Glick, 1991: 57–60). The absolute *political* desirability of continued struggles at the point of production does not quench skepticism around their *causal* implication for the profitability and crisis trends of interdependent capitalist producers on a world scale.

Clarke, on the other hand, faults productionist crisis theories for their one-sidedness and abstractness from concrete conditions of capitalist development. Insofar as crises very precisely manifest as breakdowns in the circulation of capital and the temporary but catastrophic inability to realize surplus value and to sustain the mutual convertibility of commodities and money for the purposes of renewed rounds of accumulation, then production-centric approaches clearly confine themselves to a

high level of abstraction that is ill-equipped to speak to the actual dynamics of crisis. As Clarke (1993: 143) put it,

> the tendency for the rate of profit to fall is formulated only at the most abstract level of the internal relations of capital-in-general, while the tendency to crisis is only realised in the concrete relationships between particular capitals expressed in the sphere of competition.

Crises are periodic catastrophes in the circulation process of capital, which is not as a separate sphere of circulation opposed to the sphere of production but rather encompasses both valorization and realization in capital's total process of reproduction. Crisis *theory* cannot hope to retain strong explanatory power if it does not augment its focus on valorization and the point of production with two-sided analysis capable of additionally grasping what Karl Kautsky once called "the anarchy of the market," a phrase that, for Clarke (1990: 451–452), simply means "competition" and which, in Brenner's (1999) strikingly similar vocabulary of "the anarchy of capitalist production," denotes "the competitive pressure on capitalist enterprises to cut costs as the condition for their very survival" (p. 25).

Brenner and Clarke are led by different paths toward emphasizing the conspicuous missing element from prevailing Marxist crisis theories that foreground class struggle and the immediate process of production. This missing element is an account of competition, of what Marx could simultaneously call "the inner nature of capital" and "the world as it actually is," and the extent to which capitalists are subject to profit-determining competitive pressures from their "enemy brothers" in a struggle not immediately deducible from the relation between capital and labor (Marx, 1973: 414; 1981: 134; 362; Best, 2024). In the realm of competition, a vanguard of capitalist firms adopting a more efficient production technique will compel copycat adoption by competing late entrants, on pain of extinction and in relative autonomy from the production struggles of workers. It is here, in the "horizontal" relation between capitals over the "vertical" relation between capital and labor, that Brenner (2006: 25) situates his crisis theory. Ellen Meiksins Woods (1999) called Brenner's bending of the stick away from capital-labor struggles and toward intercapitalist competition a kind of "heresy," because it activated an instinctive discomfort among Brenner's Marxist readers around an apparent abandonment of the class struggle as a pillar of crisis theory. As Werner Bonefeld (1999: 5) put it, "would the continuation of capitalist crisis in the absence of working-class struggle not indicate that capital is not in a social relationship of struggle between capital and labour?" It is to this heretical crisis theory, and Clarke's reception of it, that I now turn.

The tendency to overproduction

Clarke's otherwise acrid review of *The Economics of Global Turbulence* contains one point of unequivocal praise: "For all the weaknesses of Brenner's theoretical formulation of the problem, he does highlight what Marx characterised as the fundamental tendency of capitalist accumulation, the systemic tendency to overproduction" (Clarke, 1999: 63). In this section, I argue that Brenner's theory of competition-based profitability decline, *contra* Clarke's own harsh diagnosis on Brenner, is deeply compatible with the theory of

the tendency to overproduction that Clarke worked out in his major 1980s–1990s texts on crisis. Such an argument must also double as a defense of Brenner's controversial theory of competition, which has come under fire from Marxists for committing the same sin of "neo-Smithian Marxism" that Brenner (1977) had mercilessly critiqued two decades earlier (Fine et al., 1999; Lebowitz, 1999).

The first principle of crisis behind Clarke's (1993) theory of the tendency to overproduction is the axiom that capitalists are objectively impelled to produce surplus value as an ironclad imperative and therefore driven to develop the productive forces without limit (p. 111). But the drive to create surplus value is contradicted by the need to bring about the realization of the products of surplus labor. Without this successful realization, subsequent rounds of accumulation would be impossible. Although surplus value and profit are in the last analysis identical, it is the need for capitalists to actually realize excesses over their cost price—that is, *profitability itself*, though not necessarily the magnitude of its rate—which appears as a barrier against the tendency to accumulate without limit in accordance with capital's lawlike formula of the self-expansion of value: M-C-M. This is the fundamental contradiction of capitalist production captured in a recurring and essential concept across Clarke's intellectual corpus: "the limits of the market." On one side, the distilled drive to create surplus value barrels forward "without regard to the limits of the market" (Clarke, 1993: 76–77). Nevertheless, these limits, understood as the rocky terrain of realization, have a real and constricting social existence upon this drive for surplus value. Still, even as the limits of the market undoubtedly fetter the unlimited accumulation and the free development of the productive forces, they do not ever eliminate the drive entirely, and the expanded reproduction of capital proceeds apace in a succession of profit-based investment cycles. This dynamic contradiction, completely internal to capitalist production as a permanent and necessary condition, is what Clarke terms "the tendency to overproduction."

The underlying tendency to overproduction translates into concrete episodes of crisis through the second of Clarke's principles of crisis: the uneven development of the productive forces. Uneven development, a feature rather than a bug of capitalist accumulation, gives rise to possible disproportionalities between national capitals and branches or departments of production. But it also grounds a theory of competition by way of the notion of surplus profit. The possibility of surplus profit, as a corollary of the theory of relative surplus value (Mandel, 1999; Marx, 1976), is what constantly flickers into and recedes from view in competition, in which the tension between the uneven development of capitals and the tendential equalization of the profit rate plays out in the ordinary economic activity of capitalists. Confronted with a given set of conditions for production and realization, which are undergirded by a latent tendency to overproduce, it is only those advanced capitalists who successfully push through and expand production beyond the limits of the market—by technical advances in the production process, by the intensification and heightened exploitation of labor, and by expanding the realization of surplus value into ever-greater spatial reaches of an expanding world market—who will pocket surplus profits. This dynamic is not a seamless equalization of profit rates but a bitter interfirm scramble for surplus profits, which in turn spurs the intrafirm restructuring of the capital-labor relation and of the technical character of the direct production process. Any successful execution of technical change in the hostile field of

competition will yield arbitrage opportunities on productivity differentials that are realized in the sale of ever-greater masses of commodities. The most dynamic capitals incessantly produce beyond the limits of the market, while the backward capitals remain within its constraints. Surplus profit under conditions of uneven development thereby dictates that the necessary capitalist response to overproduction is a redoubled and further expansion of production. In this way, the actuality of competition "is no more than the everyday manifestation of the tendency to the overproduction of commodities" (Clarke, 1990: 453). When capital in a particular branch of industry does ultimately confront the limits of the market as a barrier to production, it "experiences the market as a limit in the form of a crisis" (Clark, 1999: 67).

Clarke's (1993) thinking on crisis is a product of an omnivorous engagement with the varied strands of Marxist crisis theory. His process of working through this long tradition was a careful mapping out of areas of convergence and lines of demarcation. From Friedrich Engels, Clarke conserves the orthodox foundations of the tendency to overproduction, while abandoning Engels's view of overproduction as a cyclical motor of demand–supply imbalances rather than a secular phenomenon. From the staunch critic of Marxist orthodoxy, Mikhail Tugan-Baranovsky, Clarke derives the idea that disproportionalities are the superficial manifestations of overproduction, while reproaching Tugan-Baranovsky for seeing disproportionalities as the immanent possibility of market misallocation rather than as a generalized necessity of the social relations of production. From the partisans of the LTRPF, Clarke retains the emphasis on secular tendencies of capitalist development even as he repudiates their articulation of crisis in overly abstract terms. Finally, in digesting the tradition of underconsumptionist theory from Rosa Luxemburg to Paul Sweezy, Clarke was provoked to clarify that overproduction is never understood as the obverse mirror image of underconsumption as production in excess of socially determined needs or the consumption levels of the capitalist or working classes. Rather, overproduction can only denote production in excess of the prevailing conditions of production for profit, as production for production's sake is limited and conditioned by the very need to turn a profit in order to spur renewed investment. For this reason, the most drastic outcome of crisis events is not the destruction of physical use-values but the devaluation of capital in a manner that temporarily alleviates the permanent tendency to overproduction.

If Clarke could credit Brenner for his lucidity on the tendency to overproduction, this is because both of Clarke's core principles are pillars of Brenner's (2006) framework. Brenner's "point of departure" is "simultaneously that capitalism tends to develop the productive forces to an unprecedented degree" and additionally "that it tends to do so in a destructive, because *unplanned and competitive*, manner" (p. 25). Brenner's emphasis on a theory of intercapitalist competition on the terrain of a market for manufacturing commodities *presupposes and depends upon* the drive to create ever-larger quantities of surplus value through the exploitation of workers in the production process. This is a theory of competition that builds upon, and takes as a given, Brenner's early work on the specifically capitalist social foundations of market-based competition as a spur to limitless development. In the early Brenner, the interdependence of producers locked into agonistic competition "is manifested in, and achieved through exchange on the market; but the market neither creates this interdependence, nor determines its operation," since

"the market exerts no pressure toward the *continual* revolution of the means of production" (Brenner, 1977: 37; 53). The bare existence of long-distance commerce and "the market," however anarchic, cannot alone explain why a properly capitalist form of development appears not as a "once-and-for-all improvement in the productive forces" but as "a systematic and continuous tendency or drive to transform production in the direction of greater efficiency" (Brenner, 1986: 24). Only when property relations between a class of direct producers and a class of exploiters are ossified and generalized can the impetus of capitalists to trade on the market become a generalized market *dependence*, where the reproduction and survival of individual capital depends upon successful competition with other capitals in a "mechanism of natural selection" (Brenner, 1986: 34) that transforms the drive to develop the forces of production and increase the relative surplus product into a systemic imperative (Moreno Zacarés, 2018).

In Brenner (2006), "the market" is not only an equilibrium model of competition presupposing market-dependent capitalist agents manipulated by "a malign invisible hand to go along with Adam Smith's benign one" (p. 25–26). Rather, the "intensified, horizontal intercapitalist competition" in global manufacturing makes the tendency to overproduction manifest by way of "the systematically *uneven development* of the advanced capitalist economies in the postwar period" (Brenner, 2006: 8–9) between the great US manufacturing incumbents, their rapidly industrializing German and Japanese rivals, and later, the even newer entrants of East and Southeast Asia. The notion of competition in Brenner is inextricable from the uneven development of national capitals in a drama of established incumbents and upstart new entrants. Its purpose is to explain why disproportionalities in the uneven development of the productive forces are not simply smoothed out in the competitive equalization of profit rates that should cyclically restore profitability over the course of long waves. The spanner in the works is the immobility and ponderous turnover time of fixed capital: faced with low-cost new entrants who are cutting prices to prey on the market share of incumbents, older and high-cost firms with investments already sunk into fixed capital will attempt to ride out the assault by staying in business at the price of a reduced profit rate. Surplus profits are available to the entrants relative to the incumbents, but through the protracted reality of incessant entry and insufficient exit, it runs up against the upper bound of overproduction in the line.

The root of Clarke's (1999) complaint against Brenner lies in a dispute over the employment of the fixed capital concept. As Clarke had shown some years earlier in his reading of Rudolf Hilferding (1993: 37–49), the immobility of fixed capital will certainly amplify the tendency to overproduction and induce crisis tendencies, but only on the condition that capitalists with sunk fixed capital costs base their decisions upon the *currently prevailing* profit rate, rather than a projected future profit rate that would discount the physical and moral depreciation of extant fixed capital investments. Faced with the overproduction of a glut of commodities and the overcapacity of presently employed fixed capital, why, Clarke (1999) asks, would the newer and more dynamic entrants not simply cede the battle of price skirmishes on the prevailing profit rate while winning the war of the future profit rate by buying out the fixed capital of the incumbents, closing their capacity, and cornering their market share (p. 61)? Indeed, as Clarke correctly notes, Brenner fails to demonstrate that branches of production evincing the highest concentrations of fixed capital will thereby be most prone to conditions of

overproduction. Brenner's recourse to fixed capital, then, veers far too close to seeing overproduction as an outcome of "capitalist misjudgement" and the "subjective irrationality of capitalists" (Clarke, 1993: 45), rather than as an objective necessity of capitalist production itself. If the problem surrounds an aggregated subjective tendency to overinvest rather than a systemic tendency to overproduce, then the problems of overproduction may be directly linked to a system of planned production that would prevent patterns of overinvestment from appearing in the first place.

Though not directly addressed to Clarke himself, Brenner's replies fault critics like Clarke for positioning the turnover of fixed capital in abstraction from the underlying tendency to overproduction amid the uneven development of capitals. Brenner stresses the "learning by doing" of upstart manufacturing capitals, where patterns of technological catch-up are premised neither upon incumbent leaders maintaining their technological lead nor upon the successful or unsuccessful market-share strategies of new entrants. Rather, *accumulation itself* and the experience of participating in the objective tendency to overproduce spur technological change (Brenner, 2006: 247–248). Moreover, these outgrowths of technological innovation and productivity growth in Brenner always exceed the confines of individual business cycles and therefore stretch far enough temporally to cast doubt on Clarke's accusation that Brenner is merely describing the "subjective irrationality" of capitalists making short-term investment decisions. Waves of technological change appear not as this or that improvement in a single piece of fixed capital but in a constellation of production techniques with a strong "inertial character": tangible fixed capital, intangible sunk costs like the relationships between manufacturing firms and upstream suppliers, and even the "institutional forms" and organizational structures of corporations themselves (Brenner and Glick, 1991: 89). Clarke's (2006) objection may hold for fixed capital in the abstract, but in keeping with his laser focus on the sufficient causal conditions of systemwide dynamics, Brenner insists that technological change and momentous shifts in fixed capital investment must be viewed as the introduction of "large, technically interrelated developmental blocs" (p. 32–33).

In a palpable shift away from LTRPF accounts of the overall decline in profit rates as a secular tendency, Brenner's portrait of profitability posits the hit to the profit rate as sudden and the failure to restore profitability as secular. His peculiar crisis theory might be more accurately termed a deferral-of-crisis theory. Faced with the "decreasing dynamism" and "radically increased instability" of the system (Brenner, 2006: xxvii), profitability might have—indeed, *should have*, per Clarke's overproduction theory—been restored through the actuality of crisis as what Brenner calls the "shakeout" of high-cost, low-profit firms and what Clarke prefers to describe as the unfurling of a traumatic devaluation of unprofitable capital. This is more than resonant with Clarke's theory of overproduction, in which the overall tendency remains unquenchable even if concrete episodes of crisis counteract it. While Brenner's critics have incisively argued that his extremely capacious long downturn thesis is belied by empirically demonstrable dynamics of restructuring in specific sectors (Fine et al., 2005) or new national sites of accumulation (McNally, 2010), these objections test the empirical systemwide validity of Brenner's framework without obviating his essential contribution to crisis theory: to specify the level of mediation between objective tendency and phenomenal crisis event. The morbid symptom of the long downturn is not an overabundance of crises but a

relative scarcity of crises, where the forestalling of periodic capital devaluation on massive scales precisely smothers the vitality of long-term accumulation.

The state and class struggle

If episodes of crisis are staved off at the price of intensifying secular tendencies to overproduction and declining profitability, then this katechontic function is chiefly performed by the institutional form of the capitalist state. The state is the political appearance of the mediation between the vertical capital-labor agonism and the horizontal battleground of intercapitalist competition. Through the domestic regulation of credit and the international play of currency convertibility rates, the state, as crisis manager, can at most "modify the amplitude of the cycle and the form of the crisis" or turn overcapacity into a "zero sum game" that resizes the slices of the global pie of manufacturing market share and swaps dynamism for instability in provisionally suspending the limits to accumulation (Brenner, 1999, 2009; Clarke, 1988a: 83–84).

The capitalist state, especially from the 1990s on, has forestalled the worst effects of the tendency to overproduce by making available "titanic volumes of credit" through the operations of what Brenner (2009) has memorably termed "asset price Keynesianism." Rather than draining its own coffers, as in earlier forms of Keynesian spending, the state in asset-price Keynesianism encourages firms and wealthier households to intensify *their* deficit spending through permissive interest rates, an obscene lowering of the cost of accessing credit, and the secret weapon of the United States Federal Reserve, the lender of last resort and supreme insurance policy of the financial system. But such measures, which caused a "self-perpetuating upward spiral" of asset prices and allowed individual capitalist firms to postpone their inability to reap healthy profits from their high-cost capital outlays, allowed the tendency to overproduction to march on while papering over its most destructive spasms. In Clarke's (1993) blunter terms, the intervention of the credit system on behalf of other capitalist sectors did not "introduc[e] any fundamentally new determinations of the process of capitalist production and accumulation" (p. 224). Credit apparently broadens the "limits of the market" beyond "the limits of the money in the hands of individual capitalists" (Clarke, 1988b: 107), but its real effect is to disguise overproduction in the garb of the overexpansion of credit, to misrepresent the contradictions of accumulation as mere monetary phenomena, and therefore to instill a belief in the ruling classes that increasingly prudent monetary policies of the state may yet reverse the inner movement of the system.

Concurrently, capital's response to its protracted torment by the tendency to overproduction has been to mount a merciless, well-organized assault against the working class. But the form of this offensive appeared neither as a definitive relief for profitability in some kind of inverted profit squeeze (Brenner, 2006: 146–153) nor as "a generalised offensive against the working class as a whole," but instead as "a restructuring of the institutional forms of the state and the system of industrial relations on the basis of a fragmentation of the working class" (Clarke, 1988a: 86). While class struggle in Brenner and Clarke holds no ultimately determining role in systemwide profitability and the tendency to overproduction, it reappears in crisis theory through the analytical frame of the capitalist state. As recent advances in Marxist state theory (Holdren, 2023; Hunter,

2023; O'Kane, 2023) have recognized, Clarke's (1991a; 1991b) interventions into the state debates within and beyond the CSE have established that Marxist state theory today must commence from a ground zero that avoids one of the following two extremes. It must neither succumb to an overly functionalist view of the state as an instrument of class domination and a henchman of accumulation nor to an overly structuralist view of the state as a neutral arbiter of struggle that retains autonomy from class interest. With respect to the working class, the state is neither an apparatus ripe for seizure nor a brick wall of domination. For Clarke (1991b), the expression "state theory" may itself be a misnomer, since "the state cannot be derived conceptually" and "has not developed logically out of the requirements of capital" but instead "has developed historically out of the class struggle" (pp. 184–189). If the material gains of the working class could frontally throttle the accumulation requirements of capital and inaugurate crises without mediation, or conversely, if the working class was content to acquiesce without concerted resistance to these requirements, then there would be no need for the capitalist state at all.

Although Brenner has never claimed to forward a consolidated state theory in so many words, the analysis of the form of the capitalist state is nonetheless an undeniable feature of his research on the long downturn. In Brenner, it is instructive to posit "the state" as a conceptual umbrella that encompasses a range of what he prefers to call "institutional forms" that perform state-like or regulatory functions with respect to the vertical and horizontal relations of capital. These forms include labor law, industrial relations, and the structure of the corporation, but also currency controls, Keynesian deficit spending, and central bank policy. What Brenner calls "institutional forms" are the historical manifestations of the "anonymous rule of money and law," whose imposition Clarke (1988b) traces as the historical task of the capitalist state as a social form. The class struggle produces the institutional forms of the state, which in turn appear as the limits within which class struggle occurs. More specifically, major reforms in the development of the state apparatus are contingent upon the tumult of working-class self-organization in revolt (Brenner, 2007, 2010); yet such reforms tend to produce an ossified layer of political representatives drawn from various slivers of the working class. This layer increasingly develops an interest in its own self-reproduction, which is distinct from and opposed to the interests of the very class conflict that birthed it. This political dynamic is what Brenner (1985) calls "the paradox of social democracy" (pp. 36–37) and what Clarke (1991a) calls "the central contradiction of the welfare state" (p. 59).

Fragmentation, demobilization, disorganization, and the "erosion of collective and class-based forms for pursuing workers' interests" (Brenner, 1985: 37): these are the basic historical conditions of class struggle in the long downturn, whose form of appearance is the individualizing or class-collaborationist institutional forms of the state. The state's institutional forms express the results of previous sequences of class struggle, which congeal in interests "*separate from* and [. . .] in fundamental ways *opposed to*" the interests of the working class (Brenner, 1985: 36). As the close links between waves of significant social-democratic reform and militant rank-and-file revolt illustrate (Brenner, 2010), a turn of the class struggle tide will require a sea change in the fighting capabilities of the labor movement, "which, for all its faults," Clarke (2001) writes, "is the only collective expression of the interests and aspirations of labour, in hundreds of different ways, at

every level and in every part of the world" (p. 68). But it is only in the practical crucible of concrete struggles that these new capabilities and forms of class-based organization, not to mention "hitherto irrelevant strategies" and "hitherto utopian goals requiring working-class power" (Brenner, 1985: 40), will be produced and tested. In this way, Clarke's image of capital constantly overproducing in excess of the "limits of the market" finds its counterpart in a working class that constitutes itself in struggle by "constantly pressing beyond the limits accorded to it" (Clarke, 1991b: 200).

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